

So I set my sights on Northwestern University in Chicago: the holy grail. The place that would rescue me at last! I toured the school, met with alumni, went to potential student events, got sweatshirts and shorts—the whole shebang. And then I didn't get in.

After that, I became obsessed with what school *would* go under my name on that board. I have no recollection of why Emerson College was my second choice. It might have been because at the time *The Princeton Review* website labeled it one of the gayest schools in America. As of 2018, it ranks #3 in LGBTQ student body and #7 in Least Religious Students. There was also a scholarship program at Emerson: the Honors Program. If you got in, tuition was half-off with the requirement that you'd take extra classes and write two theses. I got into both Emerson and Honors. Tuition alone was around \$37,000 per year in 2006. Now Emerson costs \$62,000 per year for room and board, food, other fees, and tuition. I wasn't at all aware of the price tag then, partly because my parents told me that I shouldn't worry about it. They didn't know I was self-harming or queer, but they knew I was miserable in Florida and they thought leaving for college would cure me.

I was desperate and ignorant—a dangerous combination. My mom bristles, but I can only imagine the number of young people who *need* to move and simply cannot make it work financially. (*We* couldn't reasonably make it work financially.) That just makes me both lucky and foolish. In hindsight, a strong money reality check would have been worth a try to avoid future mental health breakdown triggers in the form of \$30,000 in loans (which is not even on the high end of student debt for my generation).

Maybe nothing would have deterred me. There's a reason Romeo and Juliet were teenagers. Being impulsive and stubborn can be part of the deal, but it doesn't have to be.

In April 2017, I flew to Chicago to meet with seven awesome teenage girls from Gage Park High School. We ate fruit and tacos as soft jazz music played in the classroom, and we talked about their plans for the future.